

# Seawall height in Fort Lauderdale

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

FORT LAUDERDALE • BROWARD COUNTY

# 5.0

 ft NAVD88

Minimum for new or substantially rehabilitated tidal flood barrier. Applications before Jan 1, 2035 may build to 4.0 ft NAVD88 if designed to be raised to 5.0 ft by Jan 1, 2050.

## The detail

|                           |                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MINIMUM                   | 5.0 ft NAVD88                                                                                                                            |
| THE 2035 PATH             | An application filed before 1 January 2035 may build to 4.0 ft NAVD88, if the wall is designed to be raised to 5.0 ft by 1 January 2050. |
| WHAT TRIGGERS IT          | A new tidal flood barrier, or substantial rehabilitation of an existing one.                                                             |
| WHERE THE RULE COMES FROM | Broward County Code Chapter 39, Article XXV, adopted locally by the city.                                                                |

**Where this comes from:** Broward County Code Ch. 39 Art. XXV; City of Fort Lauderdale ULDR 47-19  
**Verified:** 2026-09. Rules change — check the date above against today.

## Before you call a contractor

- 1 Know your datum**  
 A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.
- 2 Get the existing elevation surveyed**  
 You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.
- 3 Ask what triggers the requirement**

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4

### **Ask about building higher now**

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.